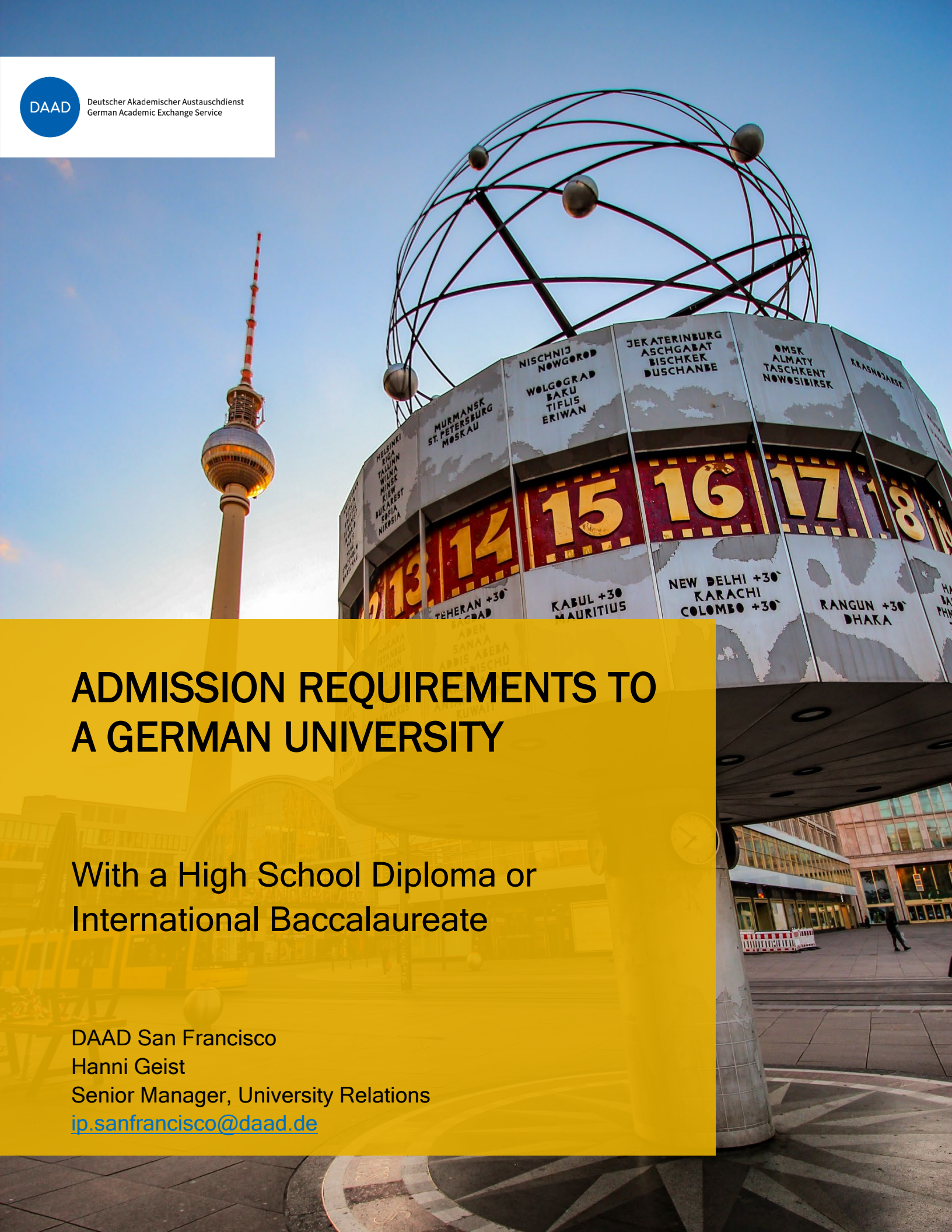


ADMISSION REQUIREMENTS TO A GERMAN UNIVERSITY

With a High School Diploma or International Baccalaureate

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Guide for Graduates with US High School Diploma or IB Diploma Seeking Admission to German Universities for an Undergraduate Degree

This guide aims to give a general overview of admission requirements. The consultation offered by DAAD USA offices is based on internal knowledge and best practices and is offered in good faith. DAAD USA, however, accepts no liability for the correctness and accuracy of the information provided. Please check Schulabschlüsse mit Hochschulzugang and choose USA or International Baccalaureate. Further information is available under KMK Bildungswesen and choose USA or International Baccalaureate for the most accurate and up-to-date information. Here is a brief explanation of what the KMK is and does. The detailed information about the requirements is only available in German, but you can set your browser to translate it into English. For clarification, please do not hesitate to contact us.

Please contact each university for specific admission requirements, required application documents, and application deadlines. We recommend that you contact the universities of your choice before you apply.

Last updated: July 2026

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General Information on Studying in Germany

Are you interested in studying in Germany at the undergraduate level? There are many things to consider. DAAD has many resources available and is your gateway to a German university. For general information about studying in Germany, visit www.daad.de and www.study-in-germany.de. These websites provide detailed information on applying to a university, finding the right program, and logistical questions, such as the visa process, health insurance, and finding accommodation.
DAAD's My GUIDE is a comprehensive tool to identify the right program and the necessary steps to make the goal of studying at a German university a reality. The news magazine Zeit offers an online tool on Zeit Campus for prospective students to identify study programs that fit their interests and their academic and professional goals.

For country-specific information for applicants from the US, visit www.daad.org.
For any questions, please contact one of our DAAD USA offices:

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Applying to a University with Late Final Transcript and Diploma or Late Test Results

Worldwide, it is common for students to not have their final diploma and transcript by the application deadline when applying for a degree program in the Winter semester of the year they graduate from high school or an IB school.
Prospective students need to contact the universities of their choice and request an extension. This is a formality, but it is a necessary step to be considered for admission. If the university accepts applications via uni-assist, they will let uni-assist know via their message portal.

German & AP German for German Heritage Speakers

Who is considered a native German speaker or German heritage speaker? Are native German speakers or German heritage speakers allowed to take German at their high school as a foreign language? This is a relevant question for families in the US that speak German either exclusively or with some family members.
In the context of German admission requirements, there are clear guidelines:
Students who have grown up in the US in a German-speaking or bilingual household, regardless of their German fluency, and attend a US high school, may take German as a foreign language.

Exception:

For students who attended school in Germany before attending school in the USA or currently attend a school in the US with German as the language of instruction, German, which is usually taught in the USA as "German as a foreign language," does not count as a foreign language.

Students who only attended a German *Grundschule* and then a US high school may take German (AP) as a foreign language. The above-mentioned rule only applies to students who left a German-speaking school after 7th grade.

German Test Requirements

Applicants, regardless of citizenship, must demonstrate their German proficiency by taking an official test if they attended a US high school. Only students who attend a German school with German as the language of instruction do not have to take a test to prove their German skills.

Applying with a High School Diploma

High School Course Requirements

German universities only accept in-person schooling. Online high school diplomas, homeschooling, and GEDs do not fulfill the high school requirements and are not accepted. You can find detailed information on course requirements on KMK Anabin Schulabschlüsse mit Hochschulzugang and a more detailed explanation on further requirements on KMK Anabin Bildungswesen.

The high school diploma must be acquired after continuous attendance of grades 9 to 12 at a US high school and must comprise a total of 16 "academic units" (1 unit = 1 year)[1]:

- 4 units of English with a minimum grade of C: English IV or Honors or AP English[2],
- 2 units of a second language (2 units of the same foreign language),
- 3 units of social studies[3]
- 5 units in total of mathematics and science:
    - 2 or 3 units of mathematics with a minimum grade of C: Algebra II or Trigonometry in grade 11 and Precalculus in grade 12 is required,
    - 2 or 3 units of Science with a minimum grade of C: biology, chemistry or physics,[4]
- 2 additional academic units of the student's choice, for example, one further unit in the languages, social studies, math, science, but also one unit in physical education, arts, or music

[1] OR continuous attendance of grades 10 to 12 at a US high school and must comprise a total of 15 "academic units" (1 unit = 1 year); in that case only 3 units of English are required.
[2] Courses for grades 11 and 12 are often given descriptive names, such as: English honors, English literature, American literature, world literature, English language and composition, and AP English.
[3] For example: American history, European history, U.S. history, world history, world societies, geography, government and politics, economics, psychology. In 9th grade, an introductory course in the social sciences is often offered; this course is called "humanities" and is also eligible for credit.
[4] Subjects like earth science or forensic science may be taken in addition, but cannot be substituted for biology, chemistry, or physics.

Eligible applicants must have an **unweighted cumulative** Grade Point Average of at least 3.0. Transcripts that only have the weighted cumulative GPA will not be considered. Please note that if only grades 10-12 are completed at a high school, only 3 units of English (with a minimum grade of C) are required, for a total of 15 academic credits.

Admission with a High School Diploma and AP or Honors courses AND AP exams – General Admission

Students with the following additional qualifications are eligible to apply to any degree program at any public German higher education institution:

A high school diploma that fulfills the above requirements (see details here) **AND**

5 Advanced Placement exams with at least a 3 in:

- Mathematics (AP calculus AB or BC)
- Natural sciences (AP biology, AP chemistry or AP physics (AP physics C: mechanics **and** AP physics C: electricity and magnetism)
- English (AP English Literature or AP English Language and Composition)
- Foreign Language (For example: AP French, AP Spanish, AP Latin, or AP German*)
- 1 additional AP subject (e.g. AP European History, AP American History, AP computer science, etc.)

Admission via High School Diploma and AP or Honors courses AND AP Exams – Subject-specific

Math, Medicine, Natural Sciences, Pharmacology and Technology

Students with the following credits are eligible to apply for field-specific admission for degree programs in the field of Mathematics, Medicine, Natural Sciences, Pharmacology or Technology, at any public German higher education institution:

A high school diploma that fulfills the above requirements (see details here) **AND**

4 Advanced Placement courses **or** Honors courses **and** AP exams with at least a 3 in:

- Mathematics (AP calculus AB or BC)
- 1 natural science (AP biology, AP chemistry or AP physics (AP physics C: mechanics **and** AP physics C: electricity and magnetism)
- 1 language (foreign languages, such as AP French, AP Spanish, AP Latin or AP German **OR** English, such as AP English Literature or AP English Language and Composition)

- 1 Additional AP subject (e.g., AP European History, AP American History, AP Computer Science, etc.)

Humanities, Social Sciences, Law and Economics/Business

To be eligible to apply for field-specific admission to degree programs in the Humanities, Social Sciences, Law, or Economics/Business, students must provide the following:

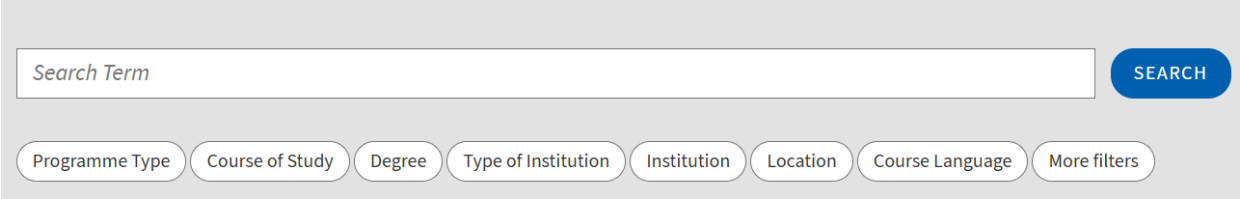
A high school diploma that fulfills the above-mentioned requirements (see details here

AND

4 Advanced Placement courses **or** Honors courses **and** AP exams with at least a 3 in:

- AP English (AP English literature or AP English language and composition)
- 1 foreign language (e.g. AP French, AP Spanish, AP Latin, or AP German). (AP German is strongly recommended.[5])
- Math or natural sciences (AP calculus AB or BC, AP biology, AP chemistry or two half AP physics C, see above.)
- 1 additional AP course (e.g. AP European history, AP American history, AP computer science, etc.)

Choose a program in the DAAD degree programs database



Admission via Studienkolleg and Feststellungsprüfung

If all high school course requirements are met, but not all AP course requirements are met, it is possible to gain admission to a German Studienkolleg. You can find more information on Studienkollegs at www.studienkollegs.de/.

[5] Please check each university and program for their language requirements. AP German is one of the 4 AP courses required for direct, subject specific admission to a university, it may, however, not be sufficient to prove language skills.

Please be sure to always submit an "official transcript of records" from the school or higher education institution with the application, clearly providing information on your subjects and grades, as well as the period of study.

The “Feststellungsprüfung” assesses the qualifications of international student applicants for entering universities in the Federal Republic of Germany.

Please note that passing the exam provides you with a subject-restricted university entrance qualification ("fachgebundene HZB"), meaning that you may only apply to a Bachelor program (or a comparable undergraduate course of study) in your subject area and related fields ("Fachrichtung").

In some Studienkollegs, you may take the "Feststellungsprüfung" without having attended the Studienkolleg ("externe Feststellungsprüfung"). In this case, students must prepare for the exam themselves. There is no comprehensive database, so those interested should search online for an “externe Feststellungsprüfung” at universities that offer the exam without requiring students to attend the classes.

Please note: Both "Universitäten" (universities) and "Fachhochschulen" (universities of applied sciences) offer Studienkollegs. A university qualification exam by a "Fachhochschule" only qualifies you to study at a "Fachhochschule," not at a "Universität." A university qualification exam by a "Universität" qualifies you to study at both types of universities: "Universitäten" and "Fachhochschulen".

Admission with a US HS Diploma and 2 years of college/Associate’s Degree

Applicants with a US high school diploma (see High School Course Requirements for Admission to a German University for details) are eligible to apply for direct admission to all fields if:

They possess a high school diploma that fulfills the above-mentioned requirements, see here

AND

- they have taken college-level courses:
  - 5 independent general education subjects: English and a foreign language, mathematics, a natural science subject, and a further subject
  - have completed at least three progressive courses in three of the above-mentioned subjects
- their transcripts show:
  a) Junior standing
  or
  b) Proof of completion of 50% of the credits required for a bachelor’s degree

or
c) an associate degree in an academic program (transfer program) with college-level courses.

Detailed information for class selection via https://anabin.kmk.org/db/bildungswesen

English: the first college-level course is typically English Composition**.** This course may be divided into multiple courses, such as College Composition I and College Composition II. In addition, courses titled Introduction to Literature or Special Topics are generally considered to be above the high school level. College English courses should focus on individual authors, literary genres, or historical periods.

Foreign language courses at a college may be taken at either the beginner or intermediate/advanced level. If a student can document at least two years of prior study of a foreign language in secondary school, these prior studies may qualify the student to begin at a higher course level. Repeating introductory language courses will not be recognized. The typical sequence of foreign language courses is Elementary I, II for beginners in a new language and Intermediate I, II for students with prior knowledge.

In mathematics, the first course considered to be college-level, as defined here, is usually College Algebra, followed by Precalculus and Calculus. At some institutions, the Precalculus course may instead be labeled Calculus I, while the actual calculus course is then designated Calculus II.
Note: Many U.S. colleges and universities, particularly community colleges and junior colleges, also offer remedial mathematics courses such as Pre-Algebra, Elementary Algebra, and Intermediate Algebra to address academic deficiencies. These courses are below the college level and therefore cannot be counted toward university admission requirements.

In the natural sciences, college-level coursework typically begins with General Physics**,** General Chemistry, and General Biology. Students are then expected to complete progressively more advanced courses in the same discipline. This progression is usually reflected by increasing course numbers (see the institution's course catalog for details). Courses with titles such as Life of Plants, Universe of Animals, or Great Ideas in Physics are generally not considered eligible for recognition.
In the social sciences, examples of college-level courses include Western Civilization I and II, American History I and II, and Microeconomics and Macroeconomics**,** among others.

Please note: Each university may require specific courses to be considered for admission to a German university. Please check course requirements in advance and get in contact with the “Akademisches Auslandsamt” of the university of your choice to make sure your course selection will be accepted.

International Baccalaureate Diploma / Diplôme du Baccalauréat International (IB)

You can find detailed information on the admission requirements for the International Baccalaureate Diploma / Diplôme du Baccalauréat International" (IB) in anabin, the database run by the Central Office for Foreign Education (ZAB):

- In anabin, choose „Schulabschlüsse mit Hochschulzugang“
- Select the „International Bacchalaureate (IB / GIB)“

For additional information and clarification, check the “Bildungswesen” page and select International Bacchalaureate (IB / GIB). Please check the www.daad.org downloads & publications page for “Information on the education system International Baccalaureate (IB GIB)” for more information clarifying the language and math requirements. You can find a supporting document with explanations for the IB language and math requirements in the “Information on the Education System International Baccalaureat (IB/GIB) on the DAAD USA publications page.

You can find the latest agreement between Germany and the IBO on recognizing the “International Baccalaureate Diploma/Diplôme du Baccalauréat International” here. Please note, the information is only available in German.

a) Among the six subjects of the "International Baccalaureate Diploma / Diplôme du Baccalauréat International" (IB), the below must be taken according to the terminology of the IB. Additionally, up-to-date information and clarification for each requirement can be found on the anabin kmk Bildungswesen page for the IB (select International Baccalaureate (IB / GIB). Applicants should check for any changes in regulations.

   - 2 languages at level A or B (of which at least one advanced foreign language is continued as "language A" or "language B HL")[6],
   - 1 natural sciences subject (biology, chemistry, physics),
   - Math: (mathematics: analysis and approaches or mathematics: applications and interpretation) **– check anabin for detailed information on math requirements since 2019**
   - 1 social sciences subject (history, geography, economics, psychology, philosophy, social anthropology, business and management, global politics).
   - The 6th compulsory subject can also be one of the following subjects as designated by the terminology of the IB: art/design, music, theater arts; film, literature and

[6] The term „continued foreign language“ implies that the language has already been studied in lower secondary education (classes/grades 5-9/10).

performance, another modern foreign language, Latin, classical Greek, general chemistry, applied chemistry, environmental systems, computer science, design technology, world religions, physical education, and health science.

b) At least one of the three subjects to be included in the "International Baccalaureate Diploma / Diplôme du Baccalauréat International" at the "Higher Level" must be either a language[7], mathematics or a natural science subject, i.e. biology, chemistry, or physics.

c) All subjects must be completed in the "IB Diploma Program" continuously, i.e. two successive years.

d) The required six subjects must be completed with an IB grade of at least 4. If one subject is graded with an IB grade of 3, it can be made up for if a subject of the same level of difficulty is completed with an IB grade of at least 5

e) a total of at least 24 points, of which at least 12 points need to be achieved on the Higher Level (HL)

Direct Admission to German Higher Education Institutions[8]

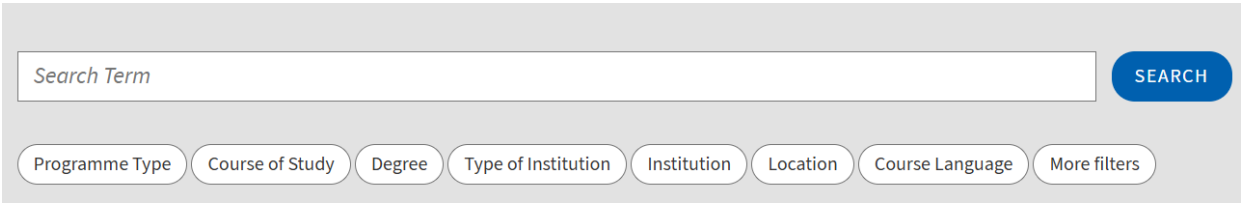
For direct admission to a German university in ALL subject areas, the following requirements need to be met in addition to the above-mentioned requirements:

IB-Diploma with a **math** course at the **Higher Level (HL)** AND **natural science** (biology, chemistry, or physics) on **Standard Level (SL)**



Direct admission, all subject areas 

Choose a program in the DAAD degree programs database



[7] Since 2023, an HL language has also been recognized. The old agreement only included math and the sciences.

[8] Higher education institutions include both universities and universities of applied sciences (Hochschulen für angewandte Wissenschaften).

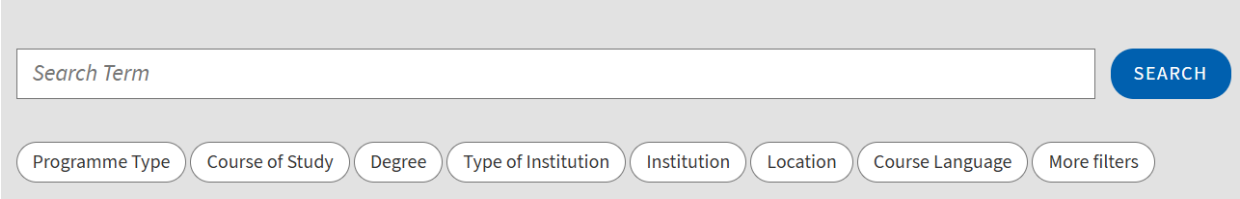
Direct, Subject-Specific Admission to a German Higher Education Institution

In addition to the above-mentioned requirements, the following requirements need to be met for direct, subject-specific admission to a German university in all subject areas:

IB-Diploma with a **math** course at the **Standard Level (SL)** AND **natural science** (biology, chemistry, or physics) on **Higher Level (HL)** OR **language on Higher Level (HL)**

Direct admission for subjects that do not belong to the mathematical-scientific-technical field[9], including medicine, humanities, and law (if all other requirements are met)[10]

Choose a program in the DAAD degree programs database



What if not all IB requirements are met for direct admission to a German university?

If a student does not meet all of the above-mentioned requirements, they may be eligible for **general admission to preparatory courses at a Studienkolleg and the university qualification exam.**

[9] Mathematik / Naturwissenschaften: Astronomie, Biologie, Chemie, Ernährungswissenschaften, Geographie, Geowissenschaften, Informatik, Nanowissenschaften, Neurowissenschaften, Pharmatechnik, Physik, Umweltwissenschaften
Technik: Architektur, Bauingenieurwesen, Bergbau, Bioingenieurwesen, Chemieingenieurwesen, Drucktechnik, Elektrotechnik, Energietechnik, Fahrzeug- und Verkehrstechnik, Gebäudeausrüstung, Geodäsie, Katastrophenschutz und -hilfe, Lebensmitteltechnologie, Luft- und Raumfahrttechnik, Maschinenbau, Mechatronik, Medientechnik, Nautik, Optische Technologien, physikalische Technik, Raumplanung, Schiffstechnik, Sicherheitswesen, Systemtechnik, Technisches Gesundheitswesen, Umweltschutz- und Entsorgungstechnik, Verfahrenstechnik, Vermessungswesen, Versorgungstechnik, Werkstoff- und Materialwissenschaften, Wirtschaftsingenieurwesen
[10] Humanities and social sciences, artistic study courses, economics and social science courses, medicine, veterinary medicine, dentistry, pharmacy, psychology, law and sports.

Studienkolleg courses are offered in various subject areas. The Studienkolleg ends with the university qualification exam, called the "**Feststellungsprüfung**".

The majority of the Studienkollegs are exclusively in German, and they require German level B1 or higher.

The “Feststellungsprüfung” assesses the qualifications of international student applicants for entering degree programs at higher education institutions in the Federal Republic of Germany. Please note that by passing the exam you will receive a subject-restricted university entrance qualification ("fachgebundene HZB"), meaning that you may apply to a bachelor’s degree program (or a comparable undergraduate course of study) in your subject area ("Fachrichtung").

At some Studienkollegs, you may take the "Feststellungsprüfung" without having attended the Studienkolleg ("externe Feststellungsprüfung"). In this case, students must prepare for the exam themselves. There is no comprehensive database, so those interested should search online for an “externe Feststellungsprüfung” at a university that offers the exam without requiring students to attend the classes. For more information about the “Feststellungsprüfung” and the difference between “intern” and “extern”, go to Studienkollegs-in.de. For more information about the tests and examples, visit Studienkolleg.com.

Please note: Both "Universitäten" (universities) and "Fachhochschulen" (universities of applied sciences) offer Studienkollegs. A university qualification exam by a "Fachhochschule" only qualifies you to study at a "Fachhochschule," not at a "Universität." A university qualification exam by a "Universität" qualifies you to study at both types of universities: "Universitäten" and "Fachhochschulen."

Information on High Schools with IB World School Accreditation

There are currently more than 800 IB high schools in the US. For a database of these schools, please visit www.ibo.org/programmes/find-an-ib-school/.
To have Germany recognize the US high school diploma or the IB diploma, all courses and exams must be completed in accordance with the KMK requirements for a high school diploma or the IB diploma.

A high school diploma with IB courses in 11th and 12th grade can only be assessed in Germany according to the criteria for the IB diploma. Recognition is only possible if the student took IB classes AND received the IB diploma. IB diploma program course results, IB certificates, and IB career-related programs are not eligible for university admission. The same applies to high school diplomas with IB courses in grades 11 and 12 but without the

final IB diploma. In these cases, admission to a German University or a Studienkolleg is not possible.

If the IB diploma has not been awarded, the evaluation of either a high school diploma or IB is not possible, i.e., applicants are not eligible for admission to a German university or a Studienkolleg.

It is therefore important to decide in advance whether to pursue the IB Diploma. If a student is unsure about this, it is advisable to obtain a US high school diploma, which also lists the courses completed according to the US curriculum. Here, the required range of subjects and the course level required by German universities must be proven; see the anabin USA page. A high school diploma, in combination with AP exams administered by the College Board, also fulfills the requirements for admission to a German university, see details in this document here.

The university and uni-assist may need a cover letter and/or additional information to recognize the coursework and final diploma. To ensure a smooth transition, please inquire about the necessary documentation in advance.